

However, there are many technical challenges that need to be overcome. There are widespread privacy concerns. Perhaps, drones for delivering parcels will be limited to just far-out and hard-to-reach places.

Germany's post office was able to beat Amazon and Google in speed with the launch of drone delivery service. France's La Poste launched a programme to use drones to deliver parcels in all weathers up to about 19km (12 miles) away.

Both Switzerland's and Finland's postal services have drone parcel delivery test projects in place. China is moving fast with drone delivery services. Its largest mail carrier, SF Express, is already using drones and delivering 500 parcels per day to remote areas. There are many more mail and courier companies with such active programmes.

Through partnerships with the government of Rwanda, Zipline delivers all blood products for twenty hospitals and healthcare centres using drones, for improving access to healthcare for millions of Rwandans.

Some challenges of using drones in a product delivery system at present are:

- Drones require longer flight times. Presently, drone flight time is limited to 20 to 25 minutes.
- Drones are noisy. With thousands flying over us, it could get extremely loud.
- Safety is a matter of concern. Drones need sophisticated collision avoidance systems.
- Drones parcel delivery systems will take both ingenuity and heaps of money.

Drones can, however, be effectively used where there is little road or rail infrastructure. Drone delivery system Flirtey conducted its first ship-to-shore drone delivery in the US on New Jersey's coastal line in June 2016. "Imagine a future where in the event of such natural disasters as Hurricane Sandy, drones can provide life-saving aid to victims of disaster in terms of medical supplies, food and water," opines Matt Sweeny, chief executive officer, Flirtey.

Blockchain war in courier and postal systems

Parcels are delivered via postal service and/or courier companies to home. Waiting for packages to be delivered, however, could be frustrating. **Blockchain having several characteristics such as being centralised, transparent, efficient, cost-effective, secure, etc can solve a number of existing problems for postal services and courier companies.** It can identify verification logistics and keep track of mails/parcels.

IBM is exploring blockchain use to accurately track and share information, and even transact between the Internet of Things (IoT) devices. Postal vehicles and sorting equipment could thereby manage their own tracking, monitoring and maintenance. Databases can do it, too. Blockchain could help all this happen automatically, making systems faster and cheaper.

If each parcel had a small sensor, blockchain could be used to manage the chain of custody between different partners. Tracking parcels on blockchain would also expedite customs clearance, and integrate payments, logistics and shipping into one cohesive platform.



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